

Rikki-Tikki-Tavi

Rudyard Kipling · 1894

First published: The Jungle Book, 1894

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Jungle_Book_(Century_edition)/"Rikki-Tikki-Tavi" (revision 11153618), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 6–8 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does Rikki-Tikki-Tavi suggest about courage?
- What does Rikki-Tikki-Tavi suggest about protecting home?
- What does Rikki-Tikki-Tavi suggest about nature and instinct?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

Primary codes: RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	Rikki-Tikki-Tavi	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*courage* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Rikki-Tikki-Tavi

Focus: courage in defense of home

Content note (animal violence, colonial setting): Sensitive content: Animal violence; colonial setting. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes animal violence; colonial setting.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

A young mongoose, washed from his burrow by a flood, is adopted by an English family in a bungalow in India. He befriends Darzee the tailorbird and learns of the cobras Nag and Nagaina. He kills the snake Karait, then Nag in the bathroom, and destroys Nagaina's eggs. Nagaina threatens the boy Teddy; Rikki lures her away, follows her into her hole and kills her.

Background: Published in The Jungle Book (1894). Kipling, born in Bombay, wrote from within British colonial India; teachers may discuss that perspective.

Significance: A widely taught middle-school story for conflict, characterization and personification.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Settle in and write for five minutes: What makes someone brave? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes animal violence; colonial setting.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
Today's words are cantonment, flinched, scuttled, bungalow, cowered. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "THIS is the story of the great war that Rikki-tikki-tavi fought single-handed, through the bath-rooms of the big bungalow in Segowlee cantonment." In this sentence it means: a permanent military station in British India. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Present the historical and literary background.
Here is what the first readers of Rikki-Tikki-Tavi would have known. Published in The Jungle Book (1894). Kipling, born in Bombay, wrote from within British colonial India; teachers may discuss that perspective. Why does this story matter? A widely taught middle-school story for conflict, characterization and personification. Write down one question you want answered.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for characterization.
Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "THIS is the story of the great war that Rikki-tikki-tavi fought single-handed, through the bath-rooms of the big bungalow in Segowlee cantonment." I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to courage in defense of home? I circle "cantonment", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find characterization, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for characterization.
Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of characterization. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.

> *THIS is the story of the great war that Rikki-tikki-tavi fought single-handed, through the bath-rooms of the big bungalow in Segowlee cantonment. Darzee, the tailor-bird, helped him, and Chuchundra, the muskrat, who never comes out into the middle of the floor, but always creeps round by the wall, gave him advice; but Rikki-tikki did the real fighting.*

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Characterization, Conflict, Personification: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how Rikki-Tikki-Tavi develops the idea of courage in defense of home. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and conflict shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to courage? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about courage in defense of home, backed by one short quotation.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how characterization shapes courage in defense of home. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.

Total: 90 minutes.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
cantonment (noun)	a permanent military station in British India	*THIS is the story of the great war that Rikki-tikki-tavi fought single-handed, through the bath-rooms of the big bungalow in Segowlee cantonment.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
flinched (verb)	pulled back quickly from fear or pain	*But just as Teddy was stooping, something flinched a little in the dust, and a tiny voice said: "Be careful.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
scuttled (verb)	ran with short quick steps	*Rikki-tikki licked his lips. "This is a splendid hunting-ground," he said, and his tail grew bottle-brushy at the thought of it, and he scuttled up and down the garden, snuffing here and there till he heard very sorrowful voices in a thorn-bush.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
bungalow (noun)	a one-story house, originally in India, with a wide veranda	*THIS is the story of the great war that Rikki-tikki-tavi fought single-handed, through the bath-rooms of the big bungalow in Segowlee cantonment.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
cowered (verb)	crouch or curl up	*Darzee and his wife only cowered down in the nest without answering, for from the thick grass at the foot of the bush there came a low hiss—a horrid cold sound that made Rikki-tikki jump back two clear feet.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
frighten (verb)	cause fear in	*"Now," said the big man (he was an Englishman who had just moved into the bungalow); "don't frighten him, and we'll see what he'll do."*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
revived (verb)	came back to life; returned	*When he revived, he was lying in the hot sun on the middle of a garden path, very draggled indeed, and a small boy was saying: "Here's a dead mongoose.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
floating (adjective)	drifting on water	*He found a little wisp of grass floating there, and clung to it till he lost his senses.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
pretend (verb)	to claim	*Darzee, if you have a grain of sense you will fly off to the stables and pretend that your wing is broken, and let Nagaina chase you away to this bush?*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. What makes someone brave?

2. Where does characterization appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with courage?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. How does Rikki-tikki come to the family? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A flood washes him to their garden
2. What are the cobras' names? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Nag and Nagaina
3. Who is Darzee? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A tailorbird
4. Where does Rikki kill Nag? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: In the bathroom
5. Whose life does Nagaina threaten? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Teddy's
6. Retell the three most important events of “Rikki-Tikki-Tavi” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A young mongoose, washed from his burrow by a flood, is adopted by an English family in a bungalow in India. He befriends Darzee the tailorbird and learns of the cobras Nag and Nagaina. He kills the snake Karait, then Nag in the bathroom, and destroys Nagaina's eggs. Nagaina threatens the boy Teddy; Rikki lures her away, follows her into her hole and kills her.
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “Rikki-Tikki-Tavi”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “Rikki-Tikki-Tavi” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “THIS is the story of the great war that Rikki-tikki-tavi fought single-handed, through the bath-rooms of the big bungalow in Segowlee cantonment.” What does “cantonment” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: cantonment: a permanent military station in British India.
10. Reread: “But just as Teddy was stooping, something flinched a little in the dust, and a tiny voice said: "Be careful.” What does “flinched” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: flinched: pulled back quickly from fear or pain.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “Rikki-Tikki-Tavi” suggest about courage in defense of home? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A widely taught middle-school story for conflict, characterization and personification.
2. Find one example of characterization in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
3. How does the conflict in this story shape what we understand about courage in defense of home? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for the forces, people or desires pulling against each other.
4. In the passage that begins “THIS is the story of the great war that Rikki-tikki-tavi fought single-handed, through the bath-rooms of the big bungalow in Segowlee cantonment.”, why might Kipling have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “Rikki-Tikki-Tavi”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A young mongoose, washed from his burrow by a flood, is adopted by an English family in a bungalow in India. He befriends Darzee the tailorbird and learns of the cobras Nag and Nagaina. He kills the snake Karait, then Nag in the bathroom, and destroys Nagaina's eggs. Nagaina threatens the boy…
6. As the opening story, what does “Rikki-Tikki-Tavi” set up that the rest of Rikki-Tikki-Tavi will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “What makes someone brave?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does personification appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with courage? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for how this element shapes meaning.
10. Background: Published in The Jungle Book (1894). Kipling, born in Bombay, wrote from within British colonial India; teachers may discuss that perspective. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “A widely taught middle-school story for conflict, characterization and personification.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

3. Rewrite one moment of "Rikki-Tikki-Tavi" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about courage in defense of home? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about "Rikki-Tikki-Tavi": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to protecting home: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Kipling need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the characterization in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how "Rikki-Tikki-Tavi" treats courage in defense of home with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Rikki-Tikki-Tavi see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve courage? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about courage in defense of home? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask Rudyard Kipling about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Conflict**: the forces, people or desires pulling against each other
- Also notice **Personification**:

Chapter quiz

1. How does Rikki-tikki come to the family?
   A. He is a gift
   B. He walks in from the jungle
   C. He is bought at a market
   D. A flood washes him to their garden
2. What are the cobras' names?
   A. Karait and Chua
   B. Nag and Nagaina
   C. Teddy and Rikki
   D. Darzee and Chuchundra

3. Who is Darzee?
   A. A muskrat
   B. A tailorbird
   C. The gardener
   D. A snake
4. Where does Rikki kill Nag?
   A. In the bathroom
   B. In the melon bed
   C. In the garden
   D. In a tree
5. Whose life does Nagaina threaten?
   A. Darzee's
   B. The father's
   C. Teddy's
   D. The mother's only
6. In the line “THIS is the story of the great war that Rikki-tikki-tavi fought single-handed, through the bathrooms of the big bungalow in Segowlee cantonment.”, what does “cantonment” most nearly mean?
   A. pulled back quickly from fear or pain
   B. a one-story house, originally in India, with a wide veranda
   C. a permanent military station in British India
   D. ran with short quick steps
7. In the line “But just as Teddy was stooping, something flinched a little in the dust, and a tiny voice said: "Be careful.”, what does “flinched” most nearly mean?
   A. ran with short quick steps
   B. pulled back quickly from fear or pain
   C. a permanent military station in British India
   D. a one-story house, originally in India, with a wide veranda

Answer key: 1. D (A flood washes him to their garden); 2. B (Nag and Nagaina); 3. B (A tailorbird); 4. A (In the bathroom); 5. C (Teddy's); 6. C (a permanent military station in British India); 7. B (pulled back quickly from fear or pain)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.3, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Rikki-Tikki-Tavi,” how does Kipling show courage in defense of home? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): In Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, how does Kipling develop the idea of courage in defense of home? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how Rikki-Tikki-Tavi develops the idea of courage in defense of home. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and conflict shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of Rikki-Tikki-Tavi (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of courage in defense of home. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what Rikki-Tikki-Tavi suggests about courage in defense of home. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's characterization and conflict), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Rudyard Kipling uses characterization in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi to complicate the reader's understanding of courage in defense of home. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate Rikki-Tikki-Tavi within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of courage in defense of home responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read Rikki-Tikki-Tavi alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of courage in defense of home follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Rikki-Tikki-Tavi and its treatment of courage in defense of home. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's characterization and conflict, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads Rikki-Tikki-Tavi as evidence for a larger claim about courage in defense of home in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads Rikki-Tikki-Tavi as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of courage in defense of home. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Rikki-Tikki-Tavi.

SAT-style questions

1. *Rikki-tikki licked his lips. "This is a splendid hunting-ground," he said, and his tail grew bottle-brushy at the thought of it, and he scuttled up and down the garden, snuffing here and there till he heard very sorrowful voices in a thorn-bush.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “scuttled” most nearly mean?

   A. ran with short quick steps

   B. came back to life; returned

   C. drifting on water

   D. to claim

2. *THIS is the story of the great war that Rikki-tikki-tavi fought single-handed, through the bath-rooms of the big bungalow in Segowlee cantonment. Darzee, the tailor-bird, helped him, and Chuchundra, the muskrat, who never comes out into the middle of the floor, but always creeps round by the wall, gave him advice; but Rikki-tikki did the real fighting.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Rikki-Tikki-Tavi”?

   A. A boy's romantic quest ending in disillusion

   B. Wishes that defy fate

   C. Courage in defense of home

   D. A choice the reader must make

SAT key: 1. A (ran with short quick steps); 2. C (Courage in defense of home)

Whole-book test

Rikki-Tikki-Tavi: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. How does Rikki-tikki come to the family?
   A. He is a gift
   B. He walks in from the jungle
   C. He is bought at a market
   D. A flood washes him to their garden
2. What are the cobras' names?
   A. Karait and Chua
   B. Nag and Nagaina
   C. Teddy and Rikki
   D. Darzee and Chuchundra
3. Who is Darzee?
   A. A muskrat
   B. A tailorbird
   C. The gardener
   D. A snake
4. Where does Rikki kill Nag?
   A. In the bathroom
   B. In the melon bed
   C. In the garden
   D. In a tree
5. Whose life does Nagaina threaten?
   A. Darzee's
   B. The father's
   C. Teddy's
   D. The mother's only
6. In the line “THIS is the story of the great war that Rikki-tikki-tavi fought single-handed, through the bathrooms of the big bungalow in Segowlee cantonment.”, what does “cantonment” most nearly mean?
   A. pulled back quickly from fear or pain
   B. a one-story house, originally in India, with a wide veranda
   C. a permanent military station in British India
   D. ran with short quick steps

7. In the line “But just as Teddy was stooping, something flinched a little in the dust, and a tiny voice said: "Be careful.”, what does “flinched” most nearly mean?
   A. ran with short quick steps
   B. pulled back quickly from fear or pain
   C. a permanent military station in British India
   D. a one-story house, originally in India, with a wide veranda
8. As used in the story (“THIS is the story of the great war that Rikki-tikki-tavi fought single-handed, through the bath-rooms of the big bungalow in Segowlee canton”), what does “cantonment” mean?
   A. a permanent military station in British India
   B. crouch or curl up
   C. drifting on water
   D. ran with short quick steps
9. As used in the story (“But just as Teddy was stooping, something flinched a little in the dust, and a tiny voice said: "Be careful.”), what does “flinched” mean?
   A. cause fear in
   B. pulled back quickly from fear or pain
   C. to claim
   D. a one-story house, originally in India, with a wide veranda
10. As used in the story (“Rikki-tikki licked his lips. "This is a splendid hunting-ground," he said, and his tail grew bottle-brushy at the thought of it, and he scut”), what does “scuttled” mean?
    A. came back to life; returned
    B. a permanent military station in British India
    C. ran with short quick steps
    D. crouch or curl up
11. As used in the story (“THIS is the story of the great war that Rikki-tikki-tavi fought single-handed, through the bath-rooms of the big bungalow in Segowlee canton”), what does “bungalow” mean?
    A. drifting on water
    B. pulled back quickly from fear or pain
    C. cause fear in
    D. a one-story house, originally in India, with a wide veranda
12. As used in the story (“Darzee and his wife only cowered down in the nest without answering, for from the thick grass at the foot of the bush there came a low hiss—”), what does “cowered” mean?
    A. crouch or curl up
    B. to claim
    C. ran with short quick steps
    D. came back to life; returned

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how courage develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

2. Explain how protecting home develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how nature and instinct develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (courage, protecting home, nature and instinct) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. D (A flood washes him to their garden); 2. B (Nag and Nagaina); 3. B (A tailorbird); 4. A (In the bathroom); 5. C (Teddy's); 6. C (a permanent military station in British India); 7. B (pulled back quickly from fear or pain); 8. A (a permanent military station in British India); 9. B (pulled back quickly from fear or pain); 10. C (ran with short quick steps); 11. D (a one-story house, originally in India, with a wide veranda); 12. A (crouch or curl up)

Essay assignments

Essay: Courage

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Rikki-Tikki-Tavi teaches about courage. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Rudyard Kipling develops courage in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Rudyard Kipling develops courage across Rikki-Tikki-Tavi. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Rikki-Tikki-Tavi (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of courage. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of courage in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Rudyard Kipling's choices in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of courage, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Rikki-Tikki-Tavi's treatment of courage in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on courage in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on courage in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi. Name your critical method, apply it

closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about courage in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on courage in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Protecting home

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Rikki-Tikki-Tavi teaches about protecting home. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Rudyard Kipling develops protecting home in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Rudyard Kipling develops protecting home across Rikki-Tikki-Tavi. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Rikki-Tikki-Tavi (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of protecting home. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of protecting home in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Rudyard Kipling's choices in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of protecting home, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Rikki-Tikki-Tavi's treatment of protecting home in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on protecting home in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on protecting home in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about protecting home in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on protecting home in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Nature and instinct

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Rikki-Tikki-Tavi teaches about nature and instinct. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Rudyard Kipling develops nature and instinct in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Rudyard Kipling develops nature and instinct across Rikki-Tikki-Tavi. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Rikki-Tikki-Tavi (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of nature and instinct. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of nature and instinct in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Rudyard Kipling's choices in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of nature and instinct, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Rikki-Tikki-Tavi's treatment of nature and instinct in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on nature and instinct in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on nature and instinct in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about nature and instinct in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on nature and instinct in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Original Liber et Libri curriculum. Quotations from the public-domain text. Vocabulary definitions are modern and contextual (curated; based on Princeton WordNet 3.0). Word histories appear only where verified (Online Etymology Dictionary, 2026-10-20); other words are student look-ups. AP and Cambridge entries are our own summaries with links, not College Board or Cambridge text; ICC-WC and LeL IDs are Liber et Libri labels. Included with every curriculum purchase and with Classroom Pro.